Careful preparation of vegetables is essential—not only do properly cut vegetables contribute to the finished appearance of a soup, they cook more evenly too.

preparing vegetables

Vegetables are best prepared just before cooking: washed, peeled, and cut ahead of time, they are left exposed to air and moisture, which can lead them to deteriorate and lose their vitamins. Most often vegetables can be cut by hand, so a good sharp knife is vital. Use a large or small knife depending on the vegetable you're cutting. Here's how to prepare those most commonly used in soups.

chopping or crushing garlic





1 Lay the clove of garlic on a cutting board with the blade of a large knife on top of it. Strike the blade with the heel of your hand to break the skin of the clove, but don't press down so hard that you smash the garlic.

2 Peel off the skin, then chop the ends off of the garlic. Chop the garlic coarsely, then sprinkle it with a little salt to keep it from sticking to the blade. You can then chop it finely or crush smooth with the flat blade.